Three First Moves While Dad Is Managing at Home

Today's help, the right people to ask, and what can wait.

Dad manages at home with a little help, and nothing has gone wrong. Everyone in the family has a view about where things are heading, and none of it is on paper.

Nothing needs deciding this month. If you'd like somewhere to begin, here are three things, in this order, taken as slowly as you like.

1 Write down the help Dad gets today

Take one ordinary week and list the tasks in it: what Dad does himself, what he gets a hand with, and from whom. Keep the things he does alone on the page; they matter as much as the help. Where you don't know how often something happens, write “not recorded” and leave it at that. Date the page and ask Dad to look it over. He'll correct what you got wrong. [1] [2]

WHY IT COMES HERE Every later conversation gets compared with this page. It's what lets the family recognize a change, and agree that it is one.

2 Ask which changes his doctor would want to hear about

At a routine visit, with Dad's say-so, put one question to the people who know his health: which changes would you want us to tell you about? Write the answer in their words, and note who in the family would make the call. The National Institute on Aging's advice about living at home as you age is to plan to revisit the decision as needs change over time. Asking now is how a family finds out whom it would go back to. [3]

WHY IT COMES HERE Which changes matter is for the professionals who know him to say. Asked while nothing is wrong, it's an ordinary question at an ordinary appointment.

3 Start a list called “Questions We'd Ask Then”

Write down what you'd want to ask if things changed, including what any help would need to be able to do for Dad. Keep each one as a question for a professional, with no answer filled in. The Family Caregiver Alliance's questions for families include one to start from: what types of help might be needed in the future? Three or four questions is plenty. [1]

WHY IT COMES HERE It's easier to write with today's page in front of you, and it keeps. Nobody has to answer it yet.

What can wait

- Where Dad might live someday. Nothing on this page asks for that.
- Whether he'll need more help, or when. The page records today and doesn't forecast.
- Looking into providers or places.
- Settling whose view of the future is right. A dated page doesn't take sides.
- What any of it means. That takes someone who assesses Dad, and the page you've written is what you'd bring them.

What isn't for the list

These three moves are for ordinary weeks. If something about Dad's health concerns you, the National Institute on Aging's advice is to suggest a visit to a health care provider. An emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Dad needs, predict what comes next or decide anything about his care. It puts three unhurried first moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You have today's help on a dated page, a question for his doctor and a short list for later. The care interview fills in the rest of the picture: it asks about every area of Dad's daily life, including the ones that are fine right now, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Writing the answers down, and the question about future help, follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to caregiving at home. Asking Dad directly, revisiting the arrangement as needs change and suggesting a visit to a health care provider follow the National Institute on Aging. The three moves and their order are ours.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.